

He describes how ice storms load the branches until they bend permanently toward the ground, creating a landscape of "Crystal shells" and "broken glass".

Yet he retains his preferred fantasy of a rural boy who methodically conquers each tree through careful swinging, learning patience and skill.

In the final moment, speaker reveals his personal connection: he too was once a birch swinger and longs to return to that state when life becomes overwhelming.

The poem concludes with his desire to climb toward heaven via a birch tree, only to be gently returned to earth, suggesting that temporary escape through imagination or nature can provide renewal for facing life's challenges.

Poetic and Stylistic techniques -

Alliteration, Consonance, Assonance, Sibilance, Repetition, Imagery, Personification, Contrast, Rhetorical Question

Symbolism - Birch trees - Childhood, imagination, freedom and escape from reality

Swinging on birches - Joy, Freedom

The Boy - Childhood, innocence

Earth - Reality, responsibilities, ordinary life

Heaven / Sky - Imagination, spiritual escape, freedom

3. Departmental -

Central Message - Human connection and empathy is important in a world that can often feel cold and impersonal.

Poetic form - Couplets

Themes - Death, Identity, Nature, Relationships

Emotions - Amusement, Confusion, Sadness

Summary -

This is a clever and satirical poem about the rules of the art world. In the final lines of this poem, the poet

emphasizes how unconscious ants are.

If one encounters something strange or new, they aren't going to investigate unless it's their job to do so. The same can be said for an ant who encounters the dead body of one of its comrades.

It's not their job to care about it. The Queen gives out commands and everyone obeys without questioning her. The poem concludes with the description of ants lives as "departmental".

Poetic and Stylistic techniques - Alliteration, Imagery, Enjambment, Personification, Irony, Allusion, Humour

Symbolism - Ants - Human Society, organized

Moth - Individual who has died, Human Morality

Ant colony - Society, bureaucracy

Department - The division of work and roles in society

Ants carrying moth - Dealing with death practical

Arthur Miller - Death of a Salesman NO

Summary and Context -

Story of Willy Loman, a 63-year-old traveling salesman, returning home exhausted from a sales trip. He has spent his life believing that success comes from being popular and attractive and financially successful.

About the writer -

Arthur Miller (1915 - 2005)

Era & Age - Contemporary American Drama, Contemporary Period (1945 - Present)

Titles - Voice of the American Dream

Admissions - Modern playwrights, Theatre Critics

Critics - Plays are overly political.

Contribution -

- Examined social realities
- Critiqued the American dream

- strengthened modern drama.

Death of a Salesman -

Willy dreams of a better future for his two sons, Biff and Happy, especially Biff, whom he believes is destined for greatness. However, Biff has failed to achieve the success Willy expects and Willy himself is struggling with his career, money, and declining confidence.

Unable to accept reality, Willy often escapes into memories of the past and his dreams of success. As the play progresses, Biff realizes that his father's idea of success is false and that they have both been living in illusions.

He tries to make Willy accept the truth and live honestly. Willy, however, cannot accept his failures and decides that his death will provide his family with life-insurance money. He deliberately causes a car accident and dies.

At his funeral, very few people attend, showing that Willy's belief that being

well-liked would bring success was an illusion. The play therefore presents Willy's tragedy as a criticism of the false promises of the American Dream and the pressure to measure human worth through money and success.

Themes - American Dream, Reality vs Illusion, Father-Son Conflict, Identity and Self Deception

Symbolism - Seeds - Growth, Hope, Legacy

Stockings - Poverty, Guilt, Betrayal, Willy's Vain

Rubber Hose - Willy's suicidal intentions

Characters - Appearance, Qualities, Representation, Relationships

Willy Loman → Aged 63, Traveling Salesman, Loman - "low man" in any
→ Ambitious, loving but misguided father, Insecure
→ Tragic failure of American dream
→ Linda Husband, Father of Biff and Happy

Bibbo Loman → 34, Willy's elder son, Handsome, physically strong
 → Independent, Emotional, self-aware
 → Self-discovery and rejection of false dreams
 → Bibbo and Willy's central conflict about reality vs illusion

Linda Loman → Middle-aged / older women
 → Loving, Patient, Loyal
 → Family Devotion and emotional support
 → Willy's wife, Bibbo's & Happy's Mother

Happy Loman → 32, Willy's younger son
 → Confident, Superficial, Insecure
 → Materialism, Superficial Success
 → Happy admires Bibbo and wants his approval but he also competes with him

Important Quotes -

1. "Attention, attention must be finally paid to such a person." - Linda argues that

ordinary people deserve dignity and respect.

2. "Be liked and you will never want." - Willy argues and believes popularity guarantees success.
3. "Nothing's planted. I don't have a thing in the ground." - Willy on failure and legacy

Unit-4

Date			
Page No.	216		

03/09/26

Emerson - Self Reliance D

Summary and Context -

This is an essay in which Emerson argues that individuals should trust themselves and their own thoughts instead of blindly following society, tradition, or public opinion.

Emerson believes that every person possesses an inner voice or intuition that can lead them toward truth. However, people often suppress their individuality because they fear criticism and want social approval.

About the writer -

Ralph Waldo Emerson (1820-1865)

Era & Age - American Renaissance, American Romantic period (1820-1865)

Titles - Father of Transcendentalism

Admirers - Walt Whitman, American intellectuals

Critics - Excessive Idealism

Date			
Page No.	217		

Contribution -

- Developed Transcendentalism.
- Advocated individualism.
- Influenced American thought and literature.

Self-Reliance -

Transcendentalism - philosophical movement that emphasizes individual intuition, spiritual freedom, nature and the belief that people can discover truth within themselves.

Self-Reliance is a key of transcendentalism.

Emerson urges people to think independently, accept their uniqueness and have confidence in their own abilities.

He also attacks conformity. Society pressures people to behave according to established rules, but Emerson believes that genuine greatness comes from those who dare to think differently. A person should not be ashamed of changing their opinions when their understanding changes.

For Emerson, self-trust, individuality,

non-Conformity and independent thinking are the foundations of a meaningful life.

Themes - Individualism, Society vs Individual

Important Quotes -

1. "Trust thyself: every heart vibrates to that iron string."

People should trust themselves. The "iron string" represents the powerful inner connection between a person and their own truth.

2. "To be yourself in a world that is constantly trying to make you something else is the greatest accomplishment."

True achievement is maintaining individual identity under pressure.

Hemingway - The Old Man and the Sea
ND

Summary and Context -

On the coast of Cuba near Havana, an old widowed fisherman named Santiago has been unable to catch a fish for 84 days. His apprentice manolin, has been forced by his parents to seek another "luckier" employer, although manolin continues to help Santiago launch and retrieve his boat from ocean each day.

About the writer -

Ernest Hemingway (1899-1961)

Era & Age - Modern Age, Modern Period (1900-1945)

Titles - Master of Minimalism

Admirees - Modern writers, Literary Critics

Critics - limited female characterization

Contribution -

• Developed concise prose style.

- Influenced modern fiction worldwide.
- Nobel prize in literature 1954

The Old man and the Sea -

On his 85th day, Santiago sails far into the sea and catches a huge marlin. The fish is extremely strong, and he struggles with it for several days.

Even though he is tired, injured and hungry, he refuses to give up because he respects the fish and wants to prove his strength and skill.

After a long struggle, he finally kills the marlin and ties it to his boat. However, sharks attack and eat the fish during his journey back. He fights the sharks but cannot save his catch.

When he reaches the shore, only the marlin's skeleton remains. Although he has lost the fish, Santiago has not truly failed because he has shown courage, patience, determination and

dignity. The story shows that a person may be defeated physically but can still remain strong and undefeated in spirit.

Themes - Man vs Nature, perseverance and Endurance, Human Dignity, Courage, Isolation and loneliness

Symbolism - Sea - Santiago calls Sea "la man", a feminine term - like a female. Kind, loving or unpredictable

- Sea is nature, life, mystery and struggle of existence.

Marlin - Strength, Dignity, Courage, the ideal opponent.

- Noble struggle and the challenge that gives life meaning.

Sharks - Destructive forces that attack success. Destruction, bad luck

Lions - Youth, strength, vitality

The mast - Santiago carries the mast on his shoulders. Suffering, endurance

Characters - Appearance, Qualities, Representation

↗ Very old fisherman, Thin and lean, worn body
 Santiago → Courageous, patient, Determined
 ↘ Human spirit ability to endure suffering and defeat without surrendering its dignity

↗ Young boy
 ↘ loyal, loving, Compassionate, Helpful, Devoted
 Manolin → Youth, Hope, loyalty, continuity

↗ Functions almost like human characters

The → Powerful, Noble, Determined
 Marlin → Santiago ideal opponent and a reflection of his own courage

↗ Aggressive
 The → Destructive, Relentless
 Sharks → Unavoidable suffering and forces that consume human achievements

Important Quotes -

1. "But man is not made for defeat." - Santiago

A person may lose physically, but the human spirit can remain undefeated.

2. "He is a great fish and I must convince him that I am a great fisherman." - Santiago

He sees the marlin as worthy of respect and wants to prove himself worthy of fighting such a powerful creature.